CACTUS FALL 2026 · WEEK 4 · LEARNING SESSION

Collect your own data

Every choice about what to collect has a consequence. Today you learn to make those choices on purpose.

Kokil Jaidka · National University of Singapore

THE IDEA

From given data to collected data

So far

Someone else collected the data and handed it to you.

Now

You decide what data exists, and who is in it.

So

Every choice has a consequence for the people in the data and for your results.

WHAT YOU MAY COLLECT

Three questions before you collect

Terms of use

What does the platform allow, and how did you read it?

Consent

Did the people who wrote this expect it to be used this way?

Ethics approval

Does your university need to approve this data and this use?

Where it is unclear, ask first. Your supervisor and your ethics office are there for this.

PUBLIC IS NOT THE SAME AS FREE TO USE

Three things that are easy to forget

A public post can be about a private moment

A person venting about their health or money did not expect to be studied.

A quote can be searched

Paste an exact sentence into a search engine, and the author may appear.

Able to is not allowed to

A script that can collect a site does not mean the site permits it.

These are prompts for discussion. They are not legal advice.

ANONYMIZATION

Removing the username is not enough

Do

Replace usernames with IDs. Remove @handles and links from the text. Keep the date, not the exact time. Drop fields you do not need.

But

A distinctive post, an exact time, and a small place can still point to one person. Ask what someone could find by searching this text.

LIVE DEMO 1

What a raw response looks like

```
{ "page": 1, "next_cursor": "cur_2",
  "items": [ { "id": "c0001", "created": "2026-10-03T14:22:05Z",
    "author": { "handle": "@..." }, "text": "...", "likes": 12 }, ... ] }
```

A **page** of items, a **cursor** to the next page, and fields you did not ask for. This is what you save, untouched.

LIVE DEMO 2

Save, log, count

1. Save raw

Write each response to a file before you change anything.

2. Log it

Query, date, tool, limits, and how many pages and items.

3. Count

Items saved, items parsed, and every difference explained.

If you cannot say what you collected, when, and how, you cannot repeat it, and nobody else can check it.

LIMITS

A limit is a plan, not a surprise

An invented example	Number
Comments you need	2,000
Items per request (page size)	up to 100
Requests allowed per day	50
Pause between requests	at least 2 seconds

At 25 per page you need 80 requests, over the limit. At 50 per page you need 40. Plan the page size and the pause before you start.

RECORD IT

The data card

What and where

What one row is, which platform, which query, which tool.

When and how much

The period, the number of items, and what was left out.

Rules and risks

Which terms and ethics apply, what you removed, who is missing, and how the posts were chosen.

You write one for your own project in the coding session, and add it to your project card.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Before the coding session

Practice page

Before You Collect, about 20 minutes. It ends with a collection stub for Colab.

Required reading

Textbook Chapter 12, section 12.1 (web APIs), and Chapter 5, section 5.3.

Your data

Bring an export you already have. If you have no data yet, tell the facilitators now. You can use the saved example in the coding session.

In the coding session: collect, parse, compare counts, anonymize, and write your data card. **Never paste a key, or real people's data, into an AI chat.**

QUESTIONS

Ask about ethics now

If a rule for your data is unclear, this is the time to say so. Better to ask before you collect than after.